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State Dems hail ruling on mail-in ballots

Trump lashes out at Supreme Court justices for blocking his efforts

By Rick Pearson
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

President Donald Trump lashed out at the U.S. Supreme Court on Tuesday for blocking his efforts to give the U.S. Postal Service power to determine who can receive and cast mail-in ballots, while top Illinois Democrats and national voting rights experts hailed the ruling and said it would prevent chaos for the Nov. 3 general election.

In an unsigned order released Monday night, the court rejected Trump's push to have the Postal Service require states to submit lists of eligible mail-in voters and use standardized, trackable ballot envelopes for delivering ballots.

Upholding a lower court order that prevented the Postal Service from enforcing the new mail-in voting rules, the high court said government lawyers were "unlikely to succeed on the merits of its challenge" and cited the close proximity of the November midterms.

The new Postal Service rules, the result of an executive order issued by Trump in March and the subject of several court challenges, were backed by two justices, Samuel Alito and Clarence Thomas. In a dissent, Alito blamed the state challenges for pushing the issue so close to the election. Justice Neil Gorsuch said he believed the rules were legal but joined the majority to block them, citing concerns that states lack the time to implement them.

Trump on Tuesday took to his Truth Social platform to air a lengthy list of grievances about court rulings that have gone against him over mail-in ballots, tariffs and his attempt to overturn birthright citizenship, writing the high court "will go down as having rendered some of the most destructive, hurtful, and damaging decisions in our Country's history."

"The damage done to America is incalculable, and they know this,

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A man on an electric scooter rides past a memorial on Tuesday for Riley O'Neil, who was killed earlier this year while riding his bike in the 3200 block of South Halsted Street in Chicago's Bridgeport neighborhood. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Aldermen call for action to improve traffic safety

Group says while city has made progress in reducing fatal crashes, 'they remain stubbornly high'

By Talia Soglin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A group of aldermen is asking the city to take steps to improve traffic safety — steps, they argue, that could have prevented the death of Chicago Department of Transportation employee Riley O'Neil in a Bridgeport traffic crash earlier this year.

O'Neil, 35, worked for a team within the city's Transportation Department that is focused on making city streets safer and preventing crashes. Bike safety advocates have said his own death could have been prevented with better bike infrastructure.

Now, 21 aldermen are calling for the city to take steps to improve traffic safety throughout the city — including by not cutting the Transportation Department's budget and exempting it from a city hiring freeze.

The aldermen also want the city's Smart Streets pilot program — which is intended, in part, to cut down on crashes by dissuading drivers from blocking bike lanes — to be made permanent and eventually expanded throughout the entire city.

"Each year dozens of people walking and biking are killed on Chicago's streets. Thousands more are seriously injured," their

letter read. "Drivers and people riding in cars are likewise killed and injured in crashes that can be prevented by better infrastructure designs and more robust investment."

Through July this year, two dozen people had been killed while walking, biking or riding motorized scooters in Chicago, according to city data. Thirty-eight people driving in motor vehicles had died.

The aldermen said that while the city "has made progress" in reducing fatal crashes on Chicago's roads, "they remain stubbornly high because of a lack of committed action."

The aldermen are asking for Chicago's Transportation Department to be made exempt from a citywide hiring freeze and for the department to see an increase in its budgeted number of traffic engineers specifically. A dearth of traffic engineers, the aldermen wrote, "is a bottleneck that delays all traffic studies and road improvements."

The aldermen also call for the city to "maintain — and where possible grow" CDOT's funding during the city's upcoming budget process, a request that could be a tall order as the city faces what

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Teresa Skwarek pays for parking at a meter box on Tuesday in Chicago's Loop. **BRIAN CASSELLA/TRIBUNE**

Looking to sweeten parking meter deal

Aldermen say concessions pried from the system's prospective new buyer

By Jake Sheridan
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicago aldermen say they are close to sweetening the deal on the city's infamous parking meter privatization by prying key concessions from the system's prospective new buyer.

A group of aldermen announced Tuesday that they have agreed with Stonepeak Partners on a pact under which the city would receive a \$75 million lump payout and get 5% of the system's future

profits, which the aldermen estimated would be worth around \$376.2 million over the remainder of the 75-year lease.

The City Council for months has pressured Stonepeak to negotiate on the terms of the lease, threatening to not approve the sale without changes to the widely reviled agreement. But with the support of several key aldermen, the New York investment firm's effort to buy the system appears a major step closer to approval.

During an unrelated news

conference Tuesday, Mayor Brandon Johnson said he hopes aldermen reach a final decision soon, maintaining his posture of carefully avoiding endorsing or opposing a sale. He praised aldermen and advisers from his administration for working to reach a deal.

"Quite frankly, some people didn't think we could come up with a better agreement. I always believed that there was a pathway forward to get a better deal," John-

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Senate panel grills Patel on changes to hiring standards

FBI boss also does not rule out sending agents to polling places

By Eric Tucker
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — FBI Director Kash Patel on Tuesday defended the bureau's loosening of hiring standards regarding an applicant's past experience with prostitution and bestiality, insisting that the changes were meant to enable victims of those acts to be considered for employment without fear of automatic disqualification.

The subject arose during a contentious Senate Judiciary Committee hearing in which Patel clashed with Democrats over his firing of agents who participated in investigations of President Donald Trump, a spate of media leak probes, and whether employees would be dispatched to the polls on Election Day in light of the bureau's ongoing election-related investigations and Trump's false claims about the existence of pervasive voter fraud.

The remarks during testi-



FBI Director Kash Patel testifies during a Senate hearing Tuesday in the Capitol in Washington. **MANUEL BALCE CENETA/AP**

mony before the Senate Judiciary Committee stood at odds with earlier comments indicating that he did not intend to send federal agents to polling places around the country. However, when Sen. Peter Welch, D-Vt., pressed the issue, Patel seemed to reverse course.

"I thought you weren't going to be sending people to the polls," Welch said.

"When did you hear that? Just another lie," Patel declared, raising his voice.

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INSIDE

Bedard 'uniquely qualified'



Blackhawks center Connor Bedard becomes the 37th player in team history to wear the captain's 'C'. "He's a natural-born leader, someone we're consistently impressed by," said Hawks general manager Kyle Davidson on Tuesday. **Sports**

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